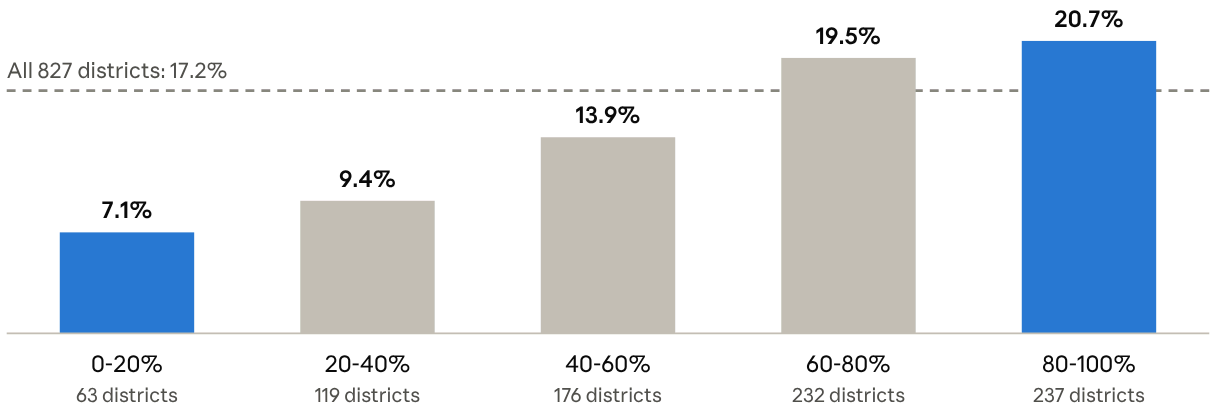
Student Need and Chronic Absenteeism in California School Districts, 2025-26

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Districts with more high-need students have more chronic absenteeism: 7.1% where under 20% of students are high-need, 20.7% where 80% or more are (827 districts, grades K-8, 2025-26). But districts with similar need differ widely, and need explains only about 17% of the variation.

Absenteeism is about 3x higher in the highest-need districts: 20.7% vs. 7.1%

Share of K-8 students chronically absent, by district high-need share, 2025-26



Rates are student-weighted: all chronically absent students in a group divided by all eligible students in it.

CDE Unduplicated Pupil Count 2025-26 and CDE Chronic Absenteeism file 2026 · 827 districts, 3.5 million K-8 students · from the Summary tab of the companion workbook

What the data show

1. **Absenteeism climbs with need.** The student-weighted rate rises from 7.1% in the lowest-need group to 20.7% in the highest, about three times as high. Districts at 60% or more high-need serve 65% of K-8 students.
2. **The climb levels off at the top.** The 60-80% group averages 19.5% and the 80% or more group 20.7%, and the median district is lower in the top group (17.7% vs. 18.6%).
3. **Need is not destiny.** Among districts at 80% or more, the middle 80% range from 8.7% to 29.7%, and 47.7% sit below the overall rate. Across all 827 districts, r = 0.41 (R^2 of 16.8%): about 1.5 points more absenteeism per 10 points of need.

How the analysis was done

I joined the CDE LCFF unduplicated pupil count (2025-26, certified January 2026) to the CDE chronic absenteeism file (2026) on the district code; 920 of 922 districts matched. High-need share is unduplicated pupils divided by total enrollment. The absenteeism rate is chronically absent students divided by eligible students (K-8). I excluded 2 unmatched districts, 53 county offices of education, 39 districts with fewer than 30 students and 1 district CDE flagged for a data error, which leaves 827. Every figure comes from live formulas in the companion Excel workbook, which has a Checks tab that reconciles the rows.

Limits

- **Association, not cause.** District averages cannot show what drives absenteeism, and they say nothing about individual students.
- **Mismatched measures.** The need share covers TK-12 enrollment while absenteeism covers K-8, and the share is one year's count used as an approximation of the LCFF funding share, not a poverty rate.
- **One year.** This is a 2025-26 snapshot with no trend.
- **Charter schools.** Some charter enrollment is probably counted inside district absenteeism rows; this was not traced school by school.

Sources

- California Department of Education, Unduplicated Pupil Count data files
- California Department of Education, Chronic Absenteeism data files, California School Dashboard
- California Department of Education, Chronic absenteeism field definitions